Unit 5 Guided Notes — The Pythagorean Theorem

ANSWER KEY

$a^2 + b^2 = c^2$. Square the legs and add to find c^2. To find a leg, subtract the squares.

🎯 By the end of this unit, I can…

- Use the Pythagorean Theorem to find a missing side of a right triangle
- Apply its converse to test whether a triangle is right
- Solve real-world and coordinate-distance problems

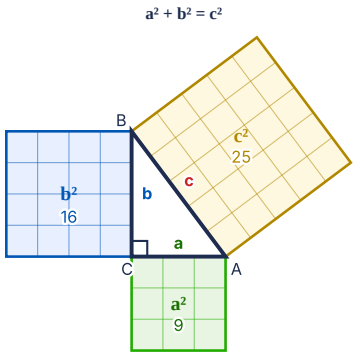
Standards: NC.8.G.6 · NC.8.G.7 · NC.8.G.8

Answer key: every blank and final answer is filled in green.

1 The Pythagorean Theorem

🔑 **THE THEOREM:** In a RIGHT triangle: leg² + leg² = hypotenuse². We write $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$.

a, b = legs (shorter sides) · c = hypotenuse (longest side, across from the right angle)



The two smaller squares (a^2+b^2) EXACTLY fill the biggest square (c^2)

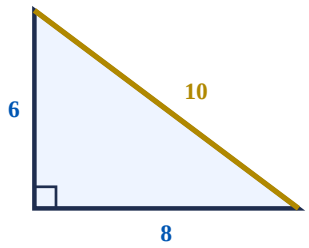
⚠️ **IMPORTANT:** The Pythagorean Theorem ONLY works on RIGHT triangles (triangles with a 90° angle)!

The two shorter sides of a right triangle are called the **LEGS** (labeled a and b). The longest side, directly across from the right angle, is the **HYPOTENUSE** (labeled c). The theorem written as an equation: $a^2 + b^2 =$ **c^2**. It applies only to **RIGHT** triangles.

✏ Practice: The Pythagorean Theorem

1. Score 3 Look at the right triangle. Which side is the hypotenuse?

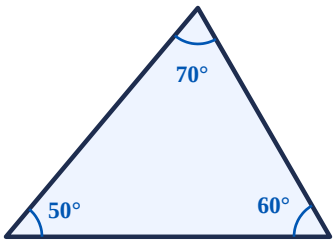
- ○ 6
- ○ 8
- ● **10**



> **How to do it:** The hypotenuse is across from the right angle (the little square). It is always the longest side. Here it is **10**.

2. Score 3 A triangle has angles of 50°, 60°, and 70°. Can you use $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ on it?

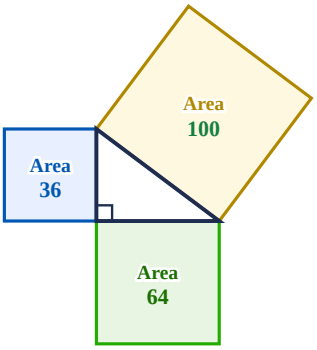
- ○ Yes
- ● **No**



> **How to do it:** No angle is 90°, so it is **not** a right triangle. The theorem only works on RIGHT triangles. Answer: **No**.

3. Score 4 The squares on the two legs of a right triangle have areas 36 and 64. What is the area of the square on the hypotenuse?

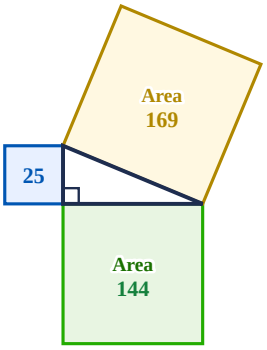
Answer: 100



> **How to do it:** $a^2 + b^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 36 + 64 = c^2 \rightarrow c^2 =$ **100**. (So the hypotenuse is $\sqrt{100} = 10$.)

4. Score 5 The square on the hypotenuse has area 169. The square on one leg has area 25. What is the area of the square on the other leg?

Answer: 144

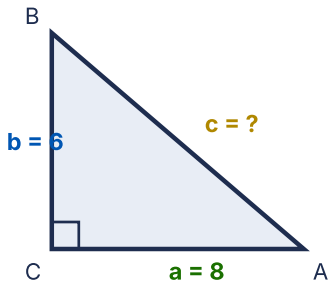


> **How to do it:** $a^2 + 25 = 169 \rightarrow a^2 = 169 - 25 =$ **144**. (So that leg is $\sqrt{144} = 12$.)

2 Finding the Hypotenuse

🔑 **WHEN TO USE:** When you know BOTH LEGS and need to find the HYPOTENUSE. Square both legs and add. Then take the square root.

FIND THE HYPOTENUSE



Example: Legs are 6 and 8. Find the hypotenuse.

Step 1 — Write formula: $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$

Step 2 — Substitute: $6^2 + 8^2 = c^2$

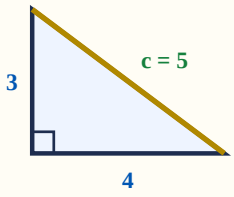
Step 3 — Square: $36 + 64 = c^2$

Step 4 — Add: $100 = c^2$

✓ **Step 5 — Square root:** $c = \sqrt{100} = 10$

Practice — Find the Hypotenuse (c)

Score 3 Legs 3 and 4: $3^2 + 4^2 = c^2 \rightarrow c = ?$

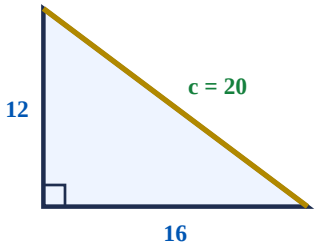


c = 5

✏ Practice: Finding the Hypotenuse

1. Score 3 The legs of a right triangle are 12 and 16. Find the hypotenuse c.

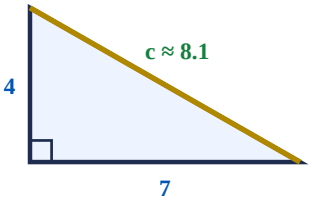
Answer: 20



How to do it: $12^2 + 16^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 144 + 256 = c^2 \rightarrow 400 = c^2 \rightarrow c = \sqrt{400} =$ **20**

2. Score 4 The legs are 4 and 7. Find the hypotenuse c. Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).

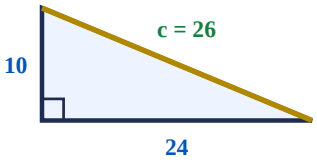
Answer: $c = \sqrt{65} \approx 8.1$



How to do it: $4^2 + 7^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 16 + 49 = c^2 \rightarrow 65 = c^2 \rightarrow c = \sqrt{65} \approx 8.062 \approx$ **8.1**

3. Score 5 The legs are 10 and 24. Maria says c = 34, because 10 + 24 = 34. What is the correct value of c?

Answer: 26



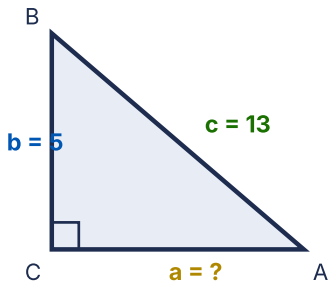
How to do it: Maria forgot to square the legs. $10^2 + 24^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 100 + 576 = 676 \rightarrow c = \sqrt{676} =$ **26**

3 Finding a Missing Leg

🔑 **WHEN TO USE:** When you know ONE LEG and the HYPOTENUSE. Square both numbers. Subtract the leg² from the hypotenuse². Then take the square root.

⚠️ **REMEMBER:** Finding a LEG = SUBTRACT from the hypotenuse squared. Finding the HYPOTENUSE = ADD the two legs squared.

FIND THE MISSING LEG



Example: One leg is 5, hypotenuse is 13. Find the other leg.

Step 1 — Write formula: $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$

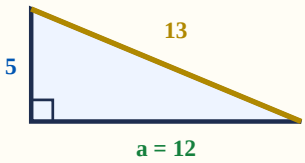
Step 2 — Substitute: $a^2 + 5^2 = 13^2$

Step 3 — Square: $a^2 + 25 = 169$

Step 4 — Subtract 25 (finding a LEG = SUBTRACT): $a^2 = 144$

✓ **Step 5 — Square root:** $a = \sqrt{144} = 12$

Score 4 **ERROR ANALYSIS** A student finds the missing leg when c = 13 and b = 5 by writing $a^2 = 13^2 + 5^2 = 194$. What is the fix?



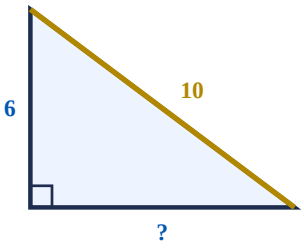
- ● **They added the squares. To find a leg, subtract: $13^2 - 5^2 = 144$, so a = 12.**
- ○ Nothing is wrong. a = √194 ≈ 13.9
- ○ They should add the sides: a = 13 + 5 = 18.
- ○ They should subtract the sides: a = 13 − 5 = 8.

✓ a is a leg, so subtract: $a^2 = 13^2 - 5^2 = 169 - 25 = 144$, and a = √144 = 12. Adding the squares is only for the hypotenuse.

✏ Practice: Finding a Missing Leg

1. Score 3 One leg is 6 and the hypotenuse is 10. Find the other leg.

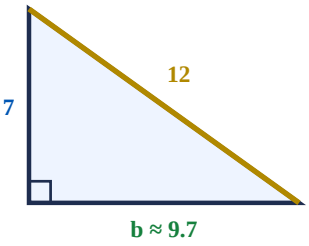
Answer: 8



How to do it: $6^2 + b^2 = 10^2 \rightarrow 36 + b^2 = 100 \rightarrow b^2 = 100 - 36 = 64 \rightarrow b = \sqrt{64} = \mathbf{8}$

2. Score 4 One leg is 7 and the hypotenuse is 12. Find the other leg. Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).

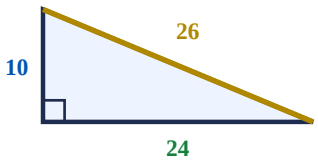
Answer: b = √95 ≈ 9.7



How to do it: $7^2 + b^2 = 12^2 \rightarrow 49 + b^2 = 144 \rightarrow b^2 = 95 \rightarrow b = \sqrt{95} \approx 9.747 \approx \mathbf{9.7}$

3. Score 5 A right triangle has a hypotenuse of 26 and one leg of 10. What is its perimeter?

Answer: 60

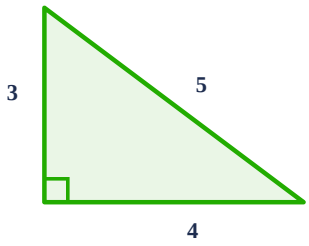


How to do it: Missing leg: $10^2 + b^2 = 26^2 \rightarrow 100 + b^2 = 676 \rightarrow b^2 = 576 \rightarrow b = 24$. Perimeter = 10 + 24 + 26 = **60**

4 Converse of the Pythagorean Theorem

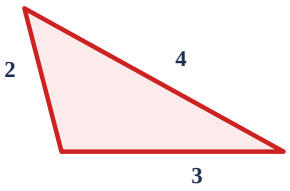
🔑 **THE CONVERSE: Converse** = the theorem turned around. Put the sides in order, smallest to largest. The largest side is c. Test: does $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$? If YES → right triangle. If NO → not a right triangle.

3, 4, 5
RIGHT triangle ✓



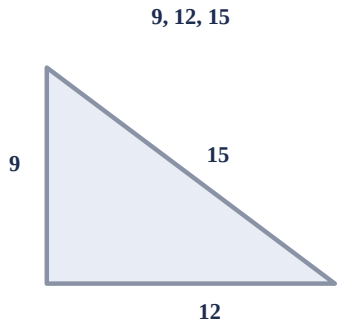
$3^2 + 4^2 = 25$ and $5^2 = 25$

2, 3, 4
NOT a right triangle ×



$2^2 + 3^2 = 13$ but $4^2 = 16$

Example: Sides 9, 12, 15. Is it a right triangle?



Step 1 — Order the sides: In order: 9, 12, 15. The largest side is c = 15

Step 2 — Write the test: does $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$?

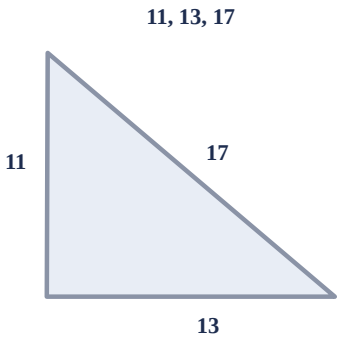
Step 3 — Substitute the two SMALLER sides: $9^2 + 12^2 =? 15^2$

Step 4 — Square each one: $81 + 144 =? 225$

Step 5 — Add the left side: $225 =? 225$

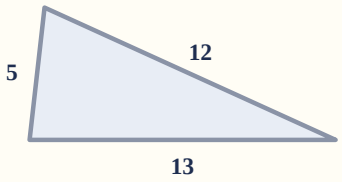
✓ **Step 6 — Compare and conclude:** The two sides are EQUAL, so YES — it is a right triangle.

⚠️ **Your eyes cannot do this job.** Every triangle below is drawn to true scale. Look at **11, 13, 17**: it is *not* a right triangle, because $11^2 + 13^2 = 121 + 169 =$ **290** while $17^2 =$ **289**. It misses by 1. The picture looks right, but it is not. Your eyes can't tell. **Always do the math.**



Quick Checks

Score 3 **MC** **Sides 5, 12, 13 — right triangle?**

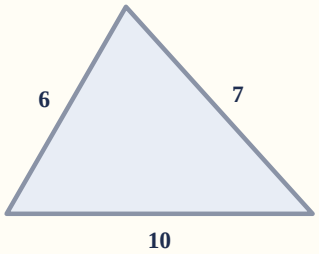


not to scale

- ● **Yes**
- ○ No

✓ $5^2 + 12^2 = 25 + 144 = 169$; $13^2 = 169$; $169 = 169$ → YES, right triangle.

Score 3 **MC** **Sides 6, 7, 10 — right triangle?**



not to scale

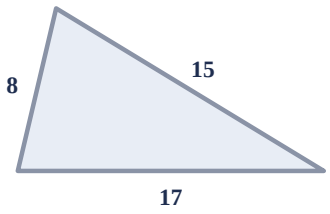
- ○ Yes
- ● **No**

✓ $6^2 + 7^2 = 36 + 49 = 85$; $10^2 = 100$; $85 \neq 100$ → NO, not a right triangle.

✏ Practice: Converse of the Pythagorean Theorem

1. Score 4 A triangle has sides 17, 8, and 15. Is it a right triangle?

- ● **Yes**
- ○ No

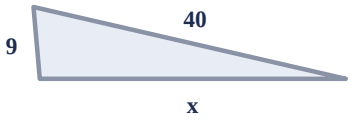


not to scale

How to do it: Put the sides in order: 8, 15, 17. Test: $8^2 + 15^2 = 64 + 225 = 289$ and $17^2 = 289$. Equal, so **Yes**.

2. Score 5 A triangle has sides 9, 40, and x. The side x is the longest. What must x be for a right triangle?

Answer: 41



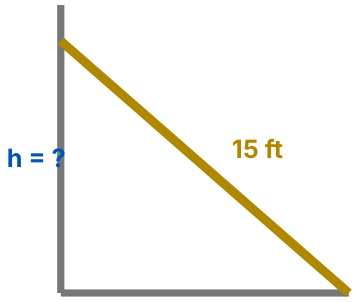
not to scale

How to do it: For a right triangle, $9^2 + 40^2 = x^2 \rightarrow 81 + 1600 = 1681 \rightarrow x = \sqrt{1681} =$ **41**

5 Word Problems

📌 **STRATEGY:** (1) Read carefully (2) Draw & label a diagram (3) Identify legs vs hypotenuse (4) Set up $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ (5) Solve step by step.

LADDER AGAINST A WALL



$9^2 + h^2 = 15^2$

Ladder Against a Wall: A ladder 15 ft long leans against a wall. The base is 9 ft from the wall. How high does it reach?

Setup: $9^2 + h^2 = 15^2$

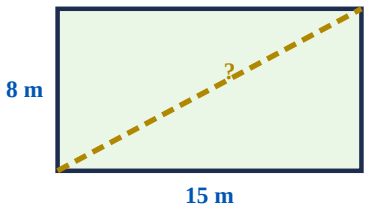
Square & subtract: $81 + h^2 = 225 \rightarrow h^2 = 144$

✓ **Square root:** $h = \sqrt{144} = 12$ ft

✏ Practice: Word Problems

1. Score 3 A rectangular garden is 15 m long and 8 m wide. A path goes from one corner to the opposite corner. How long is the path?

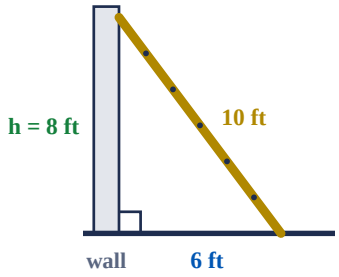
Answer: 17 m



How to do it: The path is the hypotenuse. $8^2 + 15^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 64 + 225 = 289 \rightarrow c = \sqrt{289} =$ **17 m**

2. Score 4 A 10-foot ladder leans against a wall. The bottom is 6 feet from the wall. How high up the wall does it reach?

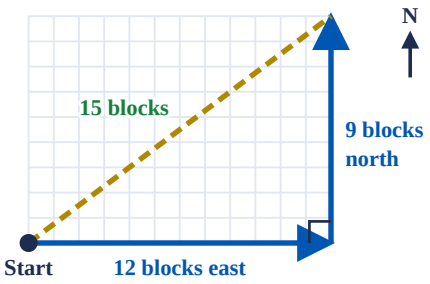
Answer: 8 ft



How to do it: The ladder is the hypotenuse. $6^2 + h^2 = 10^2 \rightarrow 36 + h^2 = 100 \rightarrow h^2 = 64 \rightarrow h = 8$ **ft**

3. Score 5 Sam walks 12 blocks east, then 9 blocks north. How many blocks shorter is the straight path back to where he started?

Answer: 6 blocks



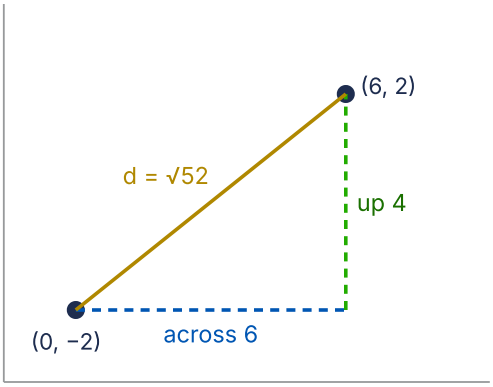
How to do it: Straight path: $12^2 + 9^2 = 144 + 81 = 225 \rightarrow \sqrt{225} = 15$ blocks. He walked 12 + 9 = 21 blocks. 21 − 15 = **6 blocks** shorter.

6 Distance on the Coordinate Plane

📐 **HOW IT WORKS:** Connect the two points to form a right triangle. Count the boxes across: bigger x − smaller x. Count the boxes up: bigger y − smaller y. These are the legs. Then use $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$. The distance is c.

⚠️ **NO DISTANCE FORMULA NEEDED!** You already know how to do this — just use the Pythagorean Theorem!

DISTANCE = HYPOTENUSE



Example: Distance from (0, −2) to (6, 2)

Across: $6 - 0 = 6$

Up: $2 - (-2) = 4$

Setup: $6^2 + 4^2 = d^2 \rightarrow 36 + 16 = 52$

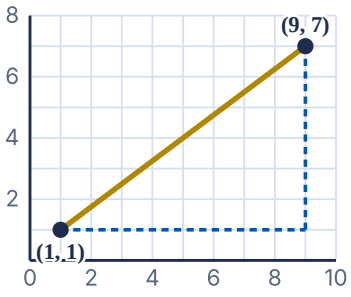
✓ **Answer:** $d = \sqrt{52} \approx 7.21$

⚠️ **WATCH YOUR SIGNS:** When subtracting negative coordinates, subtracting a negative means ADDING! Example: 5 − (−3) = 5 + 3 = 8, NOT 5 − 3 = 2.

✏ Practice: Distance on the Coordinate Plane

1. Score 3 Find the distance between (1, 1) and (9, 7).

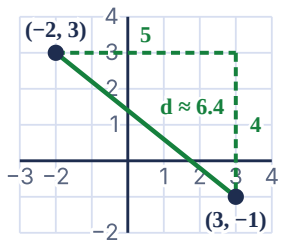
Answer: 10



How to do it: Across: 9 − 1 = 8. Up: 7 − 1 = 6. $8^2 + 6^2 = 64 + 36 = 100 \rightarrow d = \sqrt{100} =$ **10**

2. Score 4 Find the distance between (−2, 3) and (3, −1). Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).

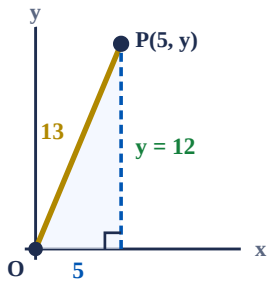
Answer: d = √41 ≈ 6.4



How to do it: Across: 3 − (−2) = 5. Down: 3 − (−1) = 4. $5^2 + 4^2 = 25 + 16 = 41$ → d = √41 ≈ 6.403 ≈ **6.4**

3. Score 5 Point P is in Quadrant I. It is 13 units from (0, 0), and its x-coordinate is 5. What is its y-coordinate?

Answer: 12



How to do it: The distance 13 is the hypotenuse and 5 is one leg. $5^2 + y^2 = 13^2$ → $25 + y^2 = 169$ → $y^2 = 144$ → y = **12**. So P = (5, 12).

✏ Part 2 — Practice, Score 3

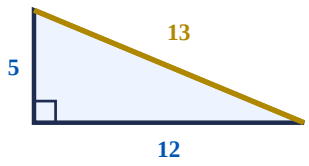
📌 **Show every step on its own line.** Box your final answer.

Every problem has a level: Score 3 Score 4 Score 5. Start with Score 3, then move up.

Score 3 Start here

1. Score 3 A right triangle has legs 5 and 12 and hypotenuse 13. Which equation is true?

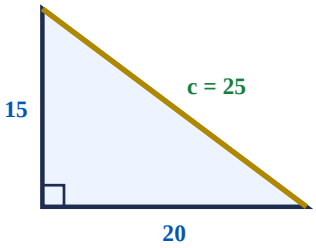
- ● **$5^2 + 12^2 = 13^2$**
- ○ $5^2 + 13^2 = 12^2$
- ○ $5 + 12 = 13$



How to do it: The two legs go on the left. The hypotenuse goes alone on the right: $5^2 + 12^2 = 13^2$ (25 + 144 = 169). **$5^2 + 12^2 = 13^2$**

2. Score 3 The legs of a right triangle are 15 and 20. Find the hypotenuse.

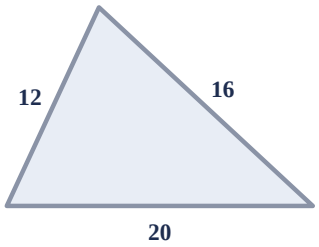
Answer: 25



How to do it: $15^2 + 20^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 225 + 400 = 625 \rightarrow c = \sqrt{625} =$ **25**

3. Score 3 A triangle has sides 12, 16, and 20. Is it a right triangle?

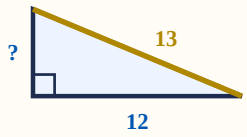
- ● **Yes**
- ○ No



not to scale

How to do it: $12^2 + 16^2 = 144 + 256 = 400$ and $20^2 = 400$. Equal, so **Yes**.

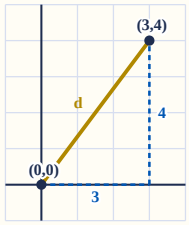
Score 3 **4) Known leg 12, hyp 13. Leg = ?**



leg =

5

Score 3 **5) (0,0) → (3,4). d = ?**



d =

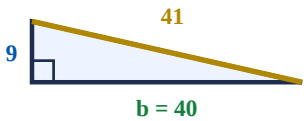
5

Part 2 — Practice, Score 4

Score 4 **On grade level**

1. Score 4 One leg is 9 and the hypotenuse is 41. Find the other leg.

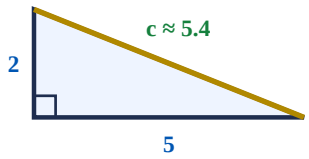
Answer: 40



How to do it: $9^2 + b^2 = 41^2 \rightarrow 81 + b^2 = 1681 \rightarrow b^2 = 1600 \rightarrow b = \sqrt{1600} =$ **40**

2. Score 4 The legs are 2 and 5. Find the hypotenuse. Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).

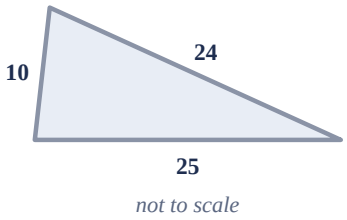
Answer: **c = √29 ≈ 5.4**



How to do it: $2^2 + 5^2 = c^2 \rightarrow 4 + 25 = 29 \rightarrow c = \sqrt{29} \approx 5.385 \approx$ **5.4**

3. Score 4 A triangle has sides 10, 24, and 25. Is it a right triangle?

- ○ Yes
- ● **No**

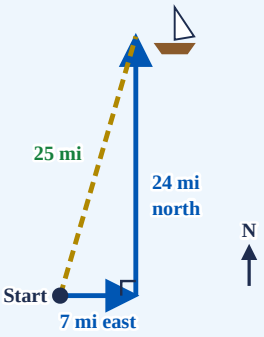


not to scale

How to do it: $10^2 + 24^2 = 100 + 576 = 676$, but $25^2 = 625$. $676 \neq 625$, so **No**.

4. Score 4 A boat sails 7 miles east, then 24 miles north. How far is it from where it started?

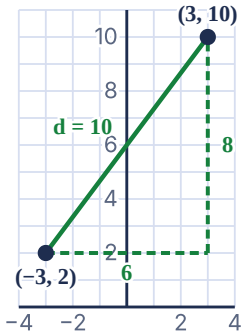
Answer: **25 miles**



How to do it: The straight-line distance is the hypotenuse. $7^2 + 24^2 = 49 + 576 = 625 \rightarrow \sqrt{625} =$ **25 miles**

5. Score 4 Find the distance between (−3, 2) and (3, 10).

Answer: 10



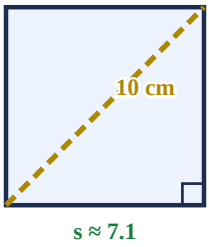
How to do it: Across: 3 − (−3) = 6. Up: 10 − 2 = 8. $6^2 + 8^2 = 36 + 64 = 100 \rightarrow d = \sqrt{100} =$ **10**

Part 2 — Practice, Score 5

Score 5 Challenge

1. Score 5 A square has a diagonal of 10 cm. How long is each side? Round to the nearest tenth (or give the exact √ answer).

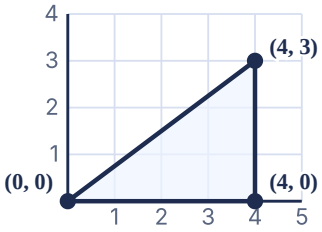
Answer: $s = \sqrt{50} \approx 7.1$ cm



How to do it: Both legs are the same length, s. $s^2 + s^2 = 10^2 \rightarrow 2s^2 = 100 \rightarrow s^2 = 50 \rightarrow s = \sqrt{50} \approx 7.071 \approx$ **7.1 cm**

2. Score 5 A triangle has corners at (0, 0), (4, 0), and (4, 3). What is its perimeter?

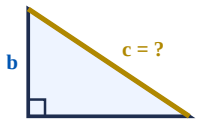
Answer: 12



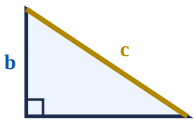
How to do it: Bottom side: 4. Right side: 3. Slanted side: $4^2 + 3^2 = 16 + 9 = 25 \rightarrow \sqrt{25} = 5$. Perimeter = 4 + 3 + 5 = **12**

3. Score 5 Which rule tells you when to ADD the squares and when to SUBTRACT them?

- **Add the squares to find the hypotenuse. Subtract the squares to find a leg.**
- Add the squares to find a leg. Subtract the squares to find the hypotenuse.
- Always add the squares of the two numbers you know.
- Add the two sides you know. Do not square them.



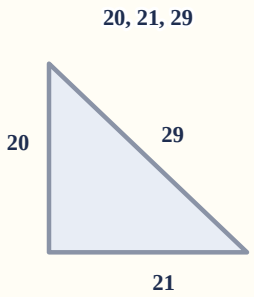
Know: a and b
Find: c



Know: b and c
Find: a

How to do it: If you know both legs and want the hypotenuse, ADD: $c^2 = a^2 + b^2$. If you know the hypotenuse and one leg, SUBTRACT: $a^2 = c^2 - b^2$.

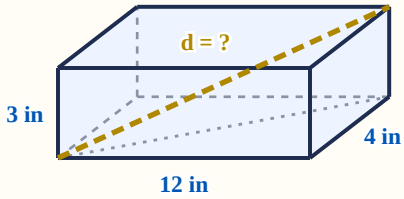
Score 5 4) Sides 20, 21, 29 — right triangle? (tap *yes* or *no*)



Answer:

Yes — $20^2 + 21^2 = 841$, and $29^2 = 841$, so $841 = 841$

Score 5 5) A box is 12 in long, 4 in wide, and 3 in tall. What is the longest straight stick that fits inside, from a bottom corner to the opposite top corner?



d = 13